

Barony

A Nation Divided...

"Beyond the great walls of our fair and prosperous cities, beyond the fertile fields of the open plains that surround them lie the barren moors, the cold forbidding mountains and the dark, sinister forests of the Empire. What horrors lie within these malignant, desolate places? What foul, twisted creatures lie in wait for unwary travellers, driven on by evil, bestial instincts? These are the dark shadows of the Empire where honest Sigmar-fearing folk dare not to tread and only desperate or foolhardy men are lured by the dark secrets that they harbour..."

This new setting for Mordheim is intended to take the fighting from the narrow, cramped streets of the ruined city and out into the untamed and dangerous wilderness of the Empire. The Empire is a deadly place outside of the reasonably safe environment of its towns and cities where the law of man prevails. The deep, dark forests harbour bands of Chaos worshipping Beastmen, bandits, mutants and much worse. Over the next seven issues of Town Cryer we will cover new rules for playing games of skirmish in the wilderness of the

Empire along with new scenarios, warbands, equipment, Hired Swords and modelling articles detailing the entirely different terrain needed. In this instalment, we will set the scene detailing the geography, history and politics of the Empire.

The Land of Sigmar

The Empire is a vast and ancient land bordered to the north by the harsh Sea of Claws beyond which lies Norsca and the Chaos Wastes. To the east are the lofty peaks of the Worlds Edge Mountains that separate the green, fertile lands of the Empire from the grim Orc-infested Dark Lands. To the south lie the Black Mountains through which is cut the heavily fortified Black Fire Pass that protects the southern approaches to the Empire. The Grey Mountains to the west form the political boundary between the Empire and the kingdom of Bretonnia. The lands of the Empire are heavily forested with only the grassy plains of the south and the fertile farming areas surrounding the towns and cities being free of such dense undergrowth.

Within these natural and political frontiers are numerous smaller, semi-autonomous states. The eight largest of these are known as electoral provinces because their rulers have each traditionally been granted a say in the election of the Emperor. They include the Principality of Reikland, the Duchy of Middenland, the Principality of Ostland, the Duchy of Talabecland, the County of Stirland, the County of Averland, the Barony of Sudenland, the County of Sylvania and the Halfling Mootland.

In 1999, the Empire lay riven with dissent, divided by the sword for there was no Emperor, and civil war raged across the land. Fear and superstition were the peasantry's only allies and the Elector Counts were divided from each other. Nowhere did the poor suffer more than the rural folk; their

lands ravaged by war, their crops and livestock burned or stolen, their pockets picked by the merciless tax collectors and their bodies wracked with famine. Despite the socio-economic breakdown of the once-mighty Empire, there still remained horrors worse than any man could devise, for wyrdstone is not exclusive to the City of the Damned. Many smaller fragments of the twin-tailed comet fell like black rain upon the lands around Mordheim, reaching for hundreds of leagues in every direction. Within the black hearts of the dark forests, the seeds of Chaos were sown and like moths to a candle were drawn the misshapen creatures of the night. And men too, for in the hearts of all men greed burns like a malevolent flame and men are more than willing to kill for just a few shards of wyrdstone.

A Rural Land...

"The Empire is known for its rural expanses. A great community exists beyond civilisation in isolation, its brooding forests and wild plains a stark and foreboding backdrop to the lonely farmsteads that pockmark the countryside. A mercantile community, its industrious wheels are forever turning, come flood, plague or famine. Traders follow the well-trodden paths through the unchecked wilds on their way to the great cities, and as ubiquitous vessels from far off lands bring exotic commodities through city drenching fog. To a man, these merchants fear the legends of fell creatures and altered men spoken of in scared whispers. Abominations that are reputed to take refuge in the dark wilderness where Imperial patrols are scarce. Others are bolder still, roaming about the city outskirts preying on the wayward or the damned."

Of Perilous Mountains

The Empire is partly bounded by three tall mountain ranges: the Grey Mountains to the west, the Black Mountains to the south and the Worlds Edge Mountains to the east. These mountains converge in the high mountainous land to the south called the Vaults. The mountains form a defensive barrier that keeps invaders out, but they also harbour many dangerous foes both on the surface and beneath their tall peaks. There are only a few passes that remain open all year, although many smaller routes can be traversed freely throughout the summer months. These permanent passes are vitally important to the security of the Empire, and it is hardly surprising that fortresses guard these strategic points.

The Grey Mountains divide the Empire from Bretonnia, the other great realm of Men in the Old World. There are Dwarf settlements within the mountains, but these are fewer in number and less wealthy than the mighty Dwarf strongholds of the Worlds Edge Mountains. The few large passes through the Grey Mountains are guarded by Bretonnian and Imperial fortresses. Most of the passes though are small and dangerous, wide enough for a merchant and his donkeys but unsuitable for carts or horses.

The largest pass lies to the south-west of Altdorf and is known as Axe Bite Pass. The Empire end of this pass is protected by the fortress of Helmgart, a massive tower that rises out of the mountainside and whose

battlements overlook the narrow path below. The northern tip of the Grey Mountains gradually declines into a hilly upland region known as the Gisoreux Gap – the principal route between Bretonnia and the Empire.

The Worlds Edge Mountains are extremely tall and almost impossible to cross where they border the Empire. There is a pass in the far north in the land of Kislev called the Peak Pass, and in the far south there is a pass where the Worlds Edge Mountains and Black Mountains divide – Black Fire Pass. In between these two routes there is no way across the surface but there are plenty of underground passages which lead under the mountains.

The Black Mountains lie between the Grey Mountains and the Worlds Edge Mountains and divide the Empire from the wild southern lands of the Border Princes. The Black Mountains are possibly the least hospitable of all the Empire's borders. The weather is unpredictable and the mountains exceptionally high as they climb towards the Vaults. The only reliable pass is Black Fire Pass, a deep cleft in the rock whose sides rise like sheer walls above the track below. The pass widens out in the middle of its length, revealing a massive upland valley. It was here that Sigmar fought his famous battle against the Orcs.

The Black Mountains are riddled with Goblin tunnels. They are crude and narrow compared to the Dwarf mines of the other

mountain chains and prone to collapsing unexpectedly. The whole mountain range is infested with Night Goblins, Trolls, Skaven and countless other less numerous, but equally deadly, creatures.

The other main upland region within the Empire is the Middle Mountains range. This lies in the northern part of the Empire and beyond it is Ostland, the northernmost of the Empire's provinces. This massive range is surrounded by dense forest and is largely shunned by humans, with the possible exception of bandits and other undesirables. There are no Dwarf delvings here, and the rocky uplands are used as a refuge by Chaos warbands, Beastmen, Orcs and marauding Goblins.

Occasionally, the Imperial forces try to clear out the worst of these foes, but the area remains wild and dangerous. The Forest of Shadows to the north is dense and dark, and inhabited by Forest Goblins and ferocious wolf packs. This is an area of the Empire which has never been truly tamed.

Of Great Rivers

Because it is surrounded by uplands, the Empire acts like a huge basin into which drain countless mountain torrents. Beginning as crashing streams and spectacular waterfalls high up in the mountains, these quickly converge to form raging rivers. By the time they reach the flat lands they have become deep and substantial – the greatest waterways in all the Old World. These deep and very broad rivers are characteristic of the Empire, where travel by boat is often faster and more practical than travel along the primitive roads.

The people of the Empire tend to refer to the areas adjoining rivers by the names of the rivers themselves, for example, Talabecland around the river Talabec, the Reikland by the banks of the Reik, and so on.

The river Sol is the southernmost of the Empire's rivers. It rises in the Vaults and its fast flowing waters are further augmented by the many streams flowing from the eastern edge of the Grey Mountains. During the spring, the Sol becomes a torrent as melt waters vastly increase the volume of water. The waters of the Sol are notoriously cold, and the hardy people that live in that region are used to the mountains and extreme climate.

The Upper Reik begins just south of Black Fire Pass where countless mountain streams converge to form what many people take as the beginnings of the mighty River Reik. Its waters are fast and crystal clear. The Upper Reik is joined by the Sol to the south of Nuln and continues northwards until it converges with the blue waters of the Aver to form the Reik at Nuln itself.

The river Aver begins as a number of fast mountain streams which flow from the western slopes of the ruined Dwarf fortress of Karak Varn just north of Black Fire Pass. Plunging over a series of tall waterfalls, these become two broad and very blue rivers which finally unite in the Moot. These rivers are the Aver Reach to the north and the Blue Reach to the south. The river Aver continues westward past the provincial capital at Averheim and finally flows into the Reik at Nuln.

The Stir may be traced to the streams, which flow from the western slopes of the Dwarf fortress of Karak Kadrin. It quickly develops into a major river flowing within a deep, wooded valley. For nearly all of its length, the Stir flows through the Great Forest and is fed by numerous springs and brooks. The great breadth of the river, and few crossing points, means that the Stir forms a defensive barrier and a natural border between Stirland to the south and Talabecland to the north. It is this river that passes through the ruins of Mordheim.

The River Talabec originates in the rapid streams of the Worlds Edge Mountains between the Dwarf fortress of Karak Kadrin and the ruins of Karak Ungor. Two main forks flow westward, the Upper and Lower Talabec, converging in dark pine forests that have an evil reputation. Here on the

borderlands of the Empire there are many roving bands of Orcs and Goblins, as well as Chaos warbands, Beastmen, and other creatures. South of where it joins the Urskoy, the river is broad and impossible to cross, becoming steadily wider as it flows west towards Talabheim.

At Talabheim there is a major ferry point, the river being far too wide to bridge. Between Talabheim and Altdorf, the river is joined by many streams that flow south from the Middle Mountains, laden with dark soils washed from the mountain slopes. Taken as a single body of water, between its source and where its waters reach the sea at Marienburg as the Reik, this is the longest and most substantial river system in the Old World.

The Reik is actually the longest single river in the Old World, although only because it bears its name from its source in the Upper Reik to where it joins the sea at Marienburg. The Talabec/Lower Reik watercourse is in fact greater in total length. The Reik is undoubtedly the most important river in the Empire, and its surrounding territories, the

Reikland, are the most prosperous. It is a busy waterway, with water traffic between Marienburg and Nuln more than 500 miles inland. This stretch of broad water actually carries more shipping than the rest of the rivers of the Empire put together, and it is the principal route for trade in the Empire. North of Nuln, the Reik is far too wide and deep to bridge. The last bridge at Nuln is one of the marvels of the Old World, and its wooden centre section can be raised and lowered to form a defensive barrier.

At Altdorf, the Reik and Talabec join together. As they do so the Talabec deposits the black soil of the Middle Mountains, forming a vast area of mud flats. The city of Altdorf is built upon an island formed of these deposits and is surrounded by marshes and islands that divide the Reik into many shifting channels. These reunite into a single large body of water just north of Altdorf, and from here the river takes on a different character. Broad and deep, it runs over a rocky bed that sometimes breaks out of the river to form steep rocky islands midstream. These islands are secure places and are used as sites for villages, small towns and even imposing fortresses. The Reik finally reaches the sea at Marienburg, the largest and wealthiest trading port and most populous city in the Old World.

Of Dark and Treacherous Forests

Most of the Empire is covered by gloomy, tangled, deciduous forests. Towards the north these turn into pine forests and eventually thin out to form the grassy plains of Kislev. The forests are wild and dangerous places, although there are towns and innumerable villages situated within the woodlands. The forests serve to hide many of the Empire's enemies, including the Forest Goblins, Chaos warbands and rampaging Orcs. The deeper forests are virtually hostile territory where few humans venture.

The Forest Of Shadows encompasses most of the principality of Ostland and lies to the north of the Middle Mountains. It is a dark and brooding pine forest thick with raiders, bandits, and Chaos warbands. The road between

Middenheim and the Kislevite city of Erengard runs through this forbidding forest.

The Reikwald Forest lies to the south of Altdorf between the River Reik and the Grey Mountains. This is a favourite haunt of the Empire's outcasts, where refugees from justice or persecution take to a life of banditry. The main road between Bretonnia and the Empire runs through this forest and climbs over Axe Bite Pass.

The Drakwald Forest lies in the area around Middenheim. It is a fairly sparse forest mostly of birch trees on a light, sandy soil. The area is not very fertile, and so has never been cleared for cultivation. In places the trees do grow more thickly and pines occur in some hilly areas. The road between Marienburg and Middenheim runs through this forest.

The Great Forest is an ancient, vast and very varied woodland, containing many majestic old oaks and hoary willows. It stretches from the Middle Mountains in the north to Nuln in the south and from Altdorf in the west to the borders of Kislev in the east. Together with the other forests of the Empire it forms a continuous block of woodland which dominates the whole central area of the Empire.

The ancient Laurelor forest lies to the north of the great city of Middenheim and marches right down to the shore of the Sea of Claws. Many believe that this forest is haunted and it contains very few human settlements. The superstitious claim that this is the last refuge of the fey Elves in the Empire and that their faerie magic and powerful illusions protect their declining numbers from harm. Most men would have nothing to do with these strange creatures and so rarely stray from the path cut by the Great North Road from Middenheim to the great city-port of Marienburg in the Wasteland.

Of Marshes and Barren Moorland

The Wasteland is a barren and windswept plain; largely inhospitable to settlement and offering little shelter from the biting winds that blow from the Sea of Claws. This land is low-lying and marshy and extends from the borders of the Reikwald Forest in the east to the foothills of the Pale Sisters in the west. It is rumoured to be home to marauding bands of Orcs and Beastmen. There are few other large stretches of marshes left in the Empire, although the County of Sylvania is renowned for its treacherous quagmires and fog covered moors. These places are full of the same manner of cut-throat rogues and mutants that lurk in the worst of the forests, and many other creatures that are far worse.

Suspicion and Mistrust...

The forests hold many dark secrets; their shadows beneath thick shrouding canopies are the haven for all manner of mutant, outlaw and freak of nature. Such secrets burst forth when the hidden moon of Morrslieb waxes full and shines its envy upon the world. Tales of great were beasts, eyes blazing red with Chaos fire, the thirst for human blood in their mouths, and of other creatures beyond description are rife and not without truth. The howling night is at its darkest beyond the safety of civilisation and the rural farmers know well of its dangers, treating all outsiders with mistrust and suspicion. Whispers are frequent of upturned coaches found abandoned on the road, footprints leading oft to bloody oblivion in some dark and forgotten corner. Possessed of a wilful ignorance, these rural men insist the desperate hammering of a beleaguered traveller was unheard, or rather unwanted, allowing such unfortunates to be swept away by the fell night creatures in the hope that they be left alone. Such is the way of suspicious men, men who seldom turn to the effigies of gods, a ripe harvest and freedom from roaming bandits taking precedence over piety towards the temples of Sigmar, Ulric and Morr. Such blind faith is far away, distant like a memory to men whose hearts are born of pragmatism rather than penitence. Seldom do they whisper the word 'Chaos' and yet the Ruinous Powers are prevalent here as they are everywhere. Altered creatures, rumoured to be part man, part beast, make their foul nests in the darkest forest depths, a rotten wound in an

already black heart, venturing forth to sack unprotected caravans and lone travellers. Screams and ululating bestial cries merge as one splitting the night and yet are unheeded; the parchment scrolls of the missing nailed to each and every way station and outpost curl and fade with age and neglect..."

Hardy Rural Folk

The wilderness of the Empire is a largely untamed, dangerous place. Those that live outside of the relative safety of the cities are a very hardy folk used to the perils of the wilds of the Empire. This is reflected in the various settlements dotted around the land, most of which are villages and farmsteads entirely dependent upon the land for their subsistence. All settlements require a source of fresh water and so are generally located close to rivers or lakes. These settlements are always partially fortified, with a wall made from wooden posts, or a palisade atop an earthwork. The living accommodation is spartan and simple, with rooms for the senior members of the family, and space in the stables and barns for retainers.

Coaching inns are found all over the Empire along the great roads that dissect the land. These are sturdily built with high stone walls and shuttered doors and windows as protection from roaming bands of Beastmen and bandits. They are incredibly important, serving as safe refuges for the many coaches and wagons that are the principal forms of transport next to the busy river traffic. Few stagecoaches travel by night, as this is a sure invitation for brutal death. Coaching inns are also useful bases for the Roadwardens, tireless marshals that patrol the roads of the Empire dealing with bandits and highwaymen and reporting problems as they find them. In times of unrest, coaching inns become the epicentres for the defence of the populace who seek protection behind their stout walls.

Other isolated places of habitation include toll-houses on busy roads, wayside shrines to the many gods of the Empire and river locks that regulate the busy traffic upon the many great rivers.

The Enemy Within...

"The roads bear the tread of many travellers. Circus folk are rife throughout the wild lands, moving from city to city across seldom-trodden paths lest they be questioned by inquisitive patrols or over-zealous witch hunters where, in the open, they are without protection from a wealthy patron. These 'entertainers' ply their unusual trade to the city-dwelling communities that are in much need of escape and humour.

Yet, there is a warning here, as much goes on beneath hoods and masks, and unnoticed agents devoted to the Ruinous Powers can slip through the nets of established order, infiltrating the cities. The cults of Chaos lie close to the heart of the Empire, its cities teeming with the players of sedition and anarchy, a subtle veil over more malicious intent. Covens of dark worshippers exist in the most disbevelled quarters and also wear the pomposity and painted smiles of the aristocracy. Evil takes many forms and for each noble exposed as a deviant Chaos worshipper there are others who remain puppets in the service of dark lords, their masters at large in the roiling lands beyond the cold stark walls of supposed order..."

Warbands of the Wilds

'Tis not just the City of the Damned that lures greedy men, for in the wilds of the Empire

there are rich pickings to be had, and not just the gold of careless travellers. Wyrdstone can be found in the deep forests of the Empire. For those brave enough to infiltrate a bandit den or the lair of Beastmen the rewards in riches and wyrdstone are insurmountable. Many of the warbands heading to Mordheim can strike it lucky upon the dark road that leads there, for most warbands are little better than thieves and bandits anyway.

Marienburgers, Reiklanders, Middenheimers, Ostlanders, Averlanders and Witch Hunters are not the only ones to be found wandering the wilds of the Empire either en-route to foul Mordheim or returning with their ill-gotten gains. There are many more sinister types to be found in the dark forests and lonely plains between the great cities. The mutated rat-people of the underworld hold sway over the land, their subterranean tunnels allowing them to appear almost anywhere at will. Who knows the extent of their infiltration? And then there are the many cults and cabals of corrupt and twisted folk who revere, rather than revile, the Dark Gods. Foolish mortals who seek to gain favour in the eyes of the mutators by paying the ultimate price of their souls. Some of these band together under the guise of travelling players and freak shows, spreading their foul infection to the ignorant and unwary as they pass through peasant abodes.

The nefarious Count von Carstein of Sylvania also covets the land and his dark claw reaches further than just the City of the Damned. For Necromancers, fell Vampires and their shambling minions can be found almost anywhere where there are burial grounds and charnel houses, defiling the dead amongst other blasphemous acts.

Bands of monstrously mutated creatures and Beastmen lurk within the dark confines of the forests. There is also rumour of creatures that are men during daylight hours but transform into ferocious creatures of fang and claw come the hours of darkness, prey upon fellow man like cattle.

And so the fight continues, not restricted to the daemon-possessed walls of a once fine city but spilling out into the provinces of the Empire of Men.